

Chapter 24

Conclusion: Challenges and Opportunities for AI in Social Work



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1 Reframing AI and Social Work

Artificial intelligence (AI) has entered social work at a moment when the profession is already grappling with widening inequalities, strained service systems, and shifting political and economic conditions (Dalziel et al., 2024). Algorithmic tools now participate in decisions about who is deemed at risk and which families receive preventive support (Reamer, 2023). They also shape how scarce resources are allocated and which narratives about need and responsibility become visible in institutional data (Coeckelbergh, 2023). These developments challenge longstanding assumptions that social work is solely a human, face-to-face enterprise. At the same time, they open the door to new forms of insight, coordination, and collective action.

As the book reveals, AI in social work is not merely a collection of technological projects. Instead, it appears as an emerging ecosystem that links infrastructures, organizations, professional roles, and community struggles. The book shows that AI is already present in the intimate spaces of counseling and casework, in the operational routines of agencies, and in the policy arenas where laws, funding streams, and rights are negotiated. The question is no longer whether AI belongs in social work. Instead, it is how its presence can be understood, contested, and reshaped so that it supports rather than undermines the profession's commitments to equity, justice, and dignity (Boetto, 2025).

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1.1 From Scattered Pilots to an Emerging Field

Early debates about AI in human services often focused on isolated pilots and prototype tools: a predictive model in one jurisdiction, a chatbot in a particular clinic, or a classification algorithm embedded in a single intake system (Huang & Rust, 2018). Viewed in isolation, such initiatives can appear as technical curiosities or local experiments. When examined collectively, however, they point toward the consolidation of a distinct field of practice and inquiry in which AI and social work are mutually entangled.

Across the book, similar questions recur. How are data about individuals, families, and communities collected, cleaned, and labeled for algorithmic use? Who defines the target outcomes that models are trained to predict? Which errors are considered tolerable and which are framed as unacceptable? These questions signal a shift from ad hoc innovation to a more systematic engagement with AI as part of the infrastructure of social welfare. The emerging field is not defined only by shared tools. It is also characterized by shared dilemmas about risk, responsibility, fairness, and care (Sun, 2025).

Recognizing this shift is essential for at least two reasons. First, it highlights the need for cumulative knowledge rather than one-off evaluations of individual systems. Second, it underscores that decisions about AI in social work are no longer confined to technical teams or individual agencies. They are distributed across professional bodies, regulators, educators, researchers, and communities. The move from scattered pilots to an emerging field is therefore also a move from individual experimentation to collective governance.

1.2 AI and Social Work Values

Much public discourse about AI in the public sector is framed in terms of efficiency, cost savings, and scalability (Kuziemski & Misuraca, 2020). These concerns matter for social work, but they are not the primary lens through which this book views AI. What is at stake is not simply whether AI can help agencies process cases more quickly or extend limited staff capacity. The central question is how algorithmic systems interact with core social work values.

AI systems participate in defining whose needs are recognized and legitimized, which harms are prioritized, and whose accounts are treated as credible. They shape the categories through which people are seen, the thresholds at which intervention is deemed warranted, and the narratives that are encoded in administrative records. In contexts marked by racism, ableism, sexism, classism, and other forms of structural oppression, AI can easily reproduce and amplify existing injustices if left unchecked (Zajko, 2022). At the same time, carefully designed systems can be used to reveal patterns of exclusion, monitor inequities, and support more responsive and inclusive forms of practice (Heeks, 2022).

For these reasons, AI in social work must be evaluated against criteria such as respect for human dignity, promotion of self-determination, advancement of social and economic justice, and commitment to collective well-being. Questions about transparency, accountability, participation, and redress are not auxiliary ethical considerations. They are central to assessing whether AI is compatible with the profession's normative commitments. The chapters in this book repeatedly show that decisions about model design, data governance, and deployment are also decisions about whose lives are made more livable and whose are rendered more precarious.

1.3 Social Workers in the Algorithmic Age

In many policy debates, social workers appear only at the end of the AI pipeline as end users who must adapt to tools designed elsewhere or as potential resisters who may slow implementation. This book advances a different view. Across domains and regions, social workers are already shaping the trajectory of AI by questioning problem framings, advocating for affected communities, co-designing interventions, generating new forms of evidence, and articulating alternative imaginaries of what technology could do.

The chapters position social workers as actors who inhabit multiple roles in the algorithmic age. They are practitioners who navigate human-AI collaboration in everyday encounters with service users. They are organizational leaders who negotiate procurement, implementation, and internal governance of AI systems. They are educators who help students interpret and critique algorithmic tools and researchers who use AI both as an object of study and as a method for inquiry. They are advocates who contest harmful uses of data and build alliances with other professions, social movements, and communities to demand more just technological arrangements.

Seeing social workers in this way has significant implications. It challenges narratives that cast AI as an external force that arrives in human services and emphasizes the agency of professionals and communities in shaping how technology is imagined, built, and governed. It also suggests that the skills and commitments cultivated within social work, including critical reflexivity, relational practice, and attention to power, are not peripheral to debates about AI but indispensable to them.

2 An Integrative View of the Book

2.1 Part I—Foundations of AI in Social Work (Chaps. 1–2)

Part I lays the groundwork for the book by clarifying what is at stake when AI enters social work. The opening chapters frame AI not as a single tool but as a set of computational practices and infrastructures that increasingly structure how information

about people, families, and communities is generated, interpreted, and acted upon. Core concepts such as machine learning, natural language processing, and predictive analytics are introduced in relation to everyday social work environments rather than in abstraction. By tracing continuities with earlier information systems and risk assessment tools, Part I situates AI within an extended history of data-driven governance. At the same time, it underscores the new forms of scale, opacity, and automation that distinguish contemporary systems.

Chapter 1 presents AI as a cross-cutting presence in practice, education, and research. In direct practice, algorithmic systems support tasks such as risk stratification, case prioritization, eligibility screening, and resource matching. In some settings, they also mediate client interaction through chatbots and other digital interfaces. In education, AI appears in adaptive learning platforms, automated feedback tools, and simulation-based training. These systems can expand opportunities for skills development but also complicate assessment and professional formation. In research, data-intensive methods extend what can be done with administrative records, text corpora, images, and other complex datasets. They enable more fine-grained analysis of social problems and service trajectories. Throughout, Chap. 1 emphasizes that these developments unfold within social and institutional contexts marked by longstanding inequities, digital divides, and contested histories of state intervention.

Chapter 2 develops a correspondingly multifaceted ethical lens. Established social work values, such as social justice, the dignity and worth of the person, self-determination, the importance of human relationships, and professional integrity, are reinterpreted in an environment where algorithmic classifications and predictions can shape life chances. Value-oriented frameworks from bioethics, trustworthy AI guidelines, and value-sensitive design are brought into conversation with social work codes and traditions. This synthesis foregrounds questions about whose data are collected and for what purposes, how consent and confidentiality can be meaningfully upheld in large, linked datasets, and how responsibility is allocated when automated systems contribute to harmful decisions.

Several domains of ethical concern are examined in detail. The book revisits privacy and data protection in the context of the granular, linked datasets required for AI, which heighten the risks of reidentification and secondary use. Fairness and nondiscrimination are discussed through the lens of algorithmic bias and subgroup disparities in model performance, with attention to how historical patterns of racism, ableism, sexism, and classism can be encoded in training data. Transparency and explainability are treated as prerequisites for informed consent, contestation, and trust. This prompts questions about the appropriateness of highly opaque models in high-stakes social work contexts. Accountability is framed as a shared obligation across developers, vendors, agencies, practitioners, and regulators rather than as a purely individual responsibility.

Finally, Part I underscores that ethical engagement with AI must be situated within a global and cultural context. Differences in legal regimes, infrastructural capacity, and cultural norms around privacy, autonomy, and collective responsibility shape how AI systems are designed, deployed, and experienced. The foundational

chapters argue for the cultivation of AI-related competencies within social work education and ongoing professional development. These include critical data literacy, the ability to interrogate model behavior, and skills for participating in interdisciplinary collaborations. In doing so, Part I provides a conceptual and normative vocabulary that recurs throughout the book. AI is understood simultaneously as a technical development, a social practice, and a moral and political project. Its legitimacy in social work is assessed by the extent to which it advances or undermines commitments to equity, justice, and human dignity.

2.2 *Part II—AI Applications Responding to Social Needs* **(Chaps. 3–15)**

Part II shifts from foundational questions to concrete domains of practice where AI is being deployed to address social needs. Across these chapters, AI systems appear in some of the most resource-constrained and ethically charged spaces of social work, including poverty and economic insecurity, child and family welfare, health and disability, LGBTQ+ affirmation, gender-based and intimate partner violence, mental health, school contexts, substance use, aging, housing instability, criminal justice involvement, and human trafficking. The chapters show that AI is rarely introduced in neutral circumstances. It tends to enter settings where institutional mistrust is already high, where services are rationed, and where the consequences of error can be profound. At the same time, these are precisely the contexts where better coordination, earlier risk identification, and more responsive services are urgently needed.

2.2.1 Material Hardship, Health, and Disability (Chaps. 3–6)

This set of chapters examines how AI is used to address material deprivation, health inequities, and diverse forms of disability. Across these contributions, AI is applied to questions of who falls into poverty and gains access to benefits and financial services, who receives timely and appropriate health care, and how physical, cognitive, and developmental challenges are supported across the life course.

Chapter 3 focuses on poverty and economic inequality. AI-driven tools are used to identify at-risk households, forecast the impact of policy changes, detect fraud and underutilization in benefits systems, and tailor financial inclusion initiatives. The promise lies in moving from reactive responses to more anticipatory, data-informed strategies that can flag emerging hardship before it becomes entrenched. Chapter 4, however, highlights the dangers of algorithmic surveillance in welfare and social protection systems. Models can reinforce punitive logics, encode historical discrimination into eligibility rules, and subject poor communities to intensified monitoring. Social work perspectives are used to argue that AI in this domain must be oriented toward economic justice rather than merely administrative efficiency.

Chapter 5 extends this line of analysis into clinical and public health settings. AI is described as a tool for enhancing diagnosis, risk stratification, care coordination, and population health monitoring. Particular attention is paid to how data-driven methods might exacerbate or reduce disparities along race, gender, and other axes of marginalization. Discussions of electronic health records, imaging, and sensor data illustrate the potential for more precise and timely interventions. They also highlight the compounded risks associated with sensitive health information and unequal access to digital infrastructure.

Chapter 6 on physical, cognitive, and developmental challenges emphasizes assistive and rehabilitative applications. AI-enabled devices and systems are described as supporting communication, mobility, and daily living for people with disabilities. At the same time, they generate new forms of data about bodily function and behavior. The analysis foregrounds tensions between empowerment and control, autonomy and paternalism, accessibility and commercialization. Across this cluster, AI is framed as capable of enabling more responsive and individualized forms of support. This potential can only be realized, however, if design and governance center on the voices and priorities of those whose lives are most affected.

2.2.2 Identity, Relationships, and Psychosocial Well-being (Chaps. 7–10)

These chapters focus on identity, relational life, and psychosocial well-being. Here, AI is entangled with how people understand themselves and each other, how stigma and affirmation are mediated, and how interpersonal violence and distress are recognized and addressed. The chapters consider LGBTQ+ communities, sexual and intimate partner violence, mental health services, and school-based social work.

In the context of LGBTQ+ communities, AI appears both as a resource and a threat. Algorithmic methods are used to analyze online discourse, identify needs and patterns of discrimination, and design affirming digital supports. At the same time, classification systems, content moderation tools, and surveillance infrastructures can mislabel, invisibilize, or expose LGBTQ+ individuals, especially in hostile legal and cultural environments. The analysis in Chap. 7 emphasizes the importance of participatory and queer-informed approaches that resist normative assumptions about gender and sexuality.

Chapters 8 and 9 on sexual and intimate partner violence and on mental health describe AI systems that seek to detect risk, support help-seeking, and supplement scarce human resources. Natural language processing and pattern recognition are used to identify indicators of coercion, abuse, or suicidality in text, speech, and behavioral data. Chatbots and digital therapeutics provide psychoeducation, coping strategies, and crisis support. These tools can extend reach and offer greater anonymity, which may be especially valuable for survivors and people experiencing stigma. Yet they also risk trivializing complex relational dynamics, misclassifying nuanced disclosures, and responding in ways that lack cultural and trauma-informed sensitivity.

Chapter 10 examines school-based applications and shows how AI reshapes the ecology in which children and young people grow and learn. Predictive analytics and early warning systems promise to identify students who may be at risk of academic failure, behavioral difficulties, or psychosocial distress. In principle, this can enable more timely support. However, such systems can also contribute to labeling, tracking, and differential treatment, particularly along racial and socioeconomic lines. The chapter underscores that in these relational domains, AI cannot be understood only as a technical instrument. It participates in the construction of categories such as risk, resilience, deviance, and well-being. It therefore must be evaluated in terms of its effects on dignity, belonging, and relational trust.

2.2.3 High Risk, Institutional, and Life Course Contexts (Chaps. 11–15)

The next cluster of chapters follows AI into high-risk environments shaped by powerful institutions, where social workers often operate at the intersection of care and control. These chapters address substance use and addiction, aging and long-term care, housing instability and homelessness, involvement with criminal legal systems, and human trafficking.

In the substance use field, AI is used to detect patterns of use and overdose risk, personalize treatment planning, and monitor adherence and relapse. Data from health records, criminal justice systems, social media, and digital devices are combined to generate risk scores and tailor interventions. The potential benefits include more targeted outreach, better matching of services to individual needs, and earlier identification of crises. Chapter 11 also identifies significant concerns about coercion, criminalization, and the use of algorithmic tools to justify intrusive surveillance or punitive responses, particularly in communities already overpoliced and underserved.

Chapter 12 on aging and long-term care describes AI-supported monitoring, fall detection, cognitive assessment, and social robots in home and institutional settings. These technologies can enhance safety and independence. They also raise questions about privacy, autonomy, the redistribution of caregiving labor, and the risk that technological substitutes replace human contact. Chapter 13 on housing instability and homelessness highlights predictive tools for identifying individuals at risk of eviction or chronic homelessness and for prioritizing access to limited housing resources. While such systems can improve coordination and transparency, they may also encode exclusionary criteria and reproduce structural racism embedded in housing markets and social policies.

Chapters 14 and 15, dealing with criminal justice and human trafficking, bring these tensions into especially stark relief. Risk assessment instruments, predictive policing, and analytic platforms promise more rational and evidence-based decisions about detention, sentencing, supervision, and victim identification. Empirical analyses and critical perspectives, however, show how these systems often rest on historically biased data, intensify surveillance of marginalized communities, and shift discretionary power into opaque technical processes. In work on trafficking, AI

is used to mine online advertisements, communications, and movement patterns to identify potential exploitation. It also carries risks of misidentification, collateral harm to sex workers, and expanded policing of already vulnerable populations.

Across these high-risk and institutional contexts, Part II reveals a recurring pattern: AI is deployed at points where eligibility, risk, and deservingness are defined and enforced. The chapters collectively argue that any assessment of AI in these settings must therefore grapple with the politics of classification and control. They call for approaches in which social workers and affected communities actively contest problem framings, reshape data practices, and design systems that prioritize harm reduction, rights protection, and structural transformation over mere efficiency or predictive accuracy.

2.3 *Part III—AI and Social Justice in Changing Contexts* **(Chaps. 16–19)**

Part III shifts the focus from specific service domains to the wider sociopolitical environments in which AI is developed and deployed. The chapters examine how AI intersects with advocacy, environmental justice, transformations of work, and global social issues. Together, they show that AI is not only a tool used within existing welfare and service systems. It is also a force that reshapes the structural conditions under which social problems emerge, are interpreted, and are contested. Social workers appear here as actors who engage with AI at the level of movements, institutions, and transnational governance, not only at the point of individual service delivery.

Chapter 16 on advocacy and social justice highlights how AI can reconfigure the terrains on which campaigns and movements operate. Data-driven tools are used to monitor policy debates, map networks of influence, analyze social media discourse, and identify emerging narratives and misinformation. Machine learning can identify communities disproportionately affected by policy choices and help tailor messaging or resource allocation to them. At the same time, the analysis warns that the same techniques can be used to manipulate public opinion, segment constituencies in ways that exacerbate polarization, and obscure the structural roots of injustice behind individualized profiling. From a social work perspective, the chapter argues for advocacy practices that appropriate AI for critical and emancipatory purposes. This includes participatory approaches in which communities help define the problems to be analyzed, the indicators of success, and the boundaries of acceptable data use.

Environmental social work and climate change provide a second arena in which AI is deeply entangled with questions of justice. Here, AI is mobilized to analyze remote sensing data, model climate risks, monitor deforestation and pollution, and support early warning systems for disasters. These capabilities can strengthen governments' and communities' ability to anticipate and respond to environmental

hazards. They can also document uneven patterns of exposure and vulnerability across regions and populations. Chapter 17, however, shows that such systems are embedded in political economies of extraction and development. Decisions about where to monitor, which risks to prioritize, and how to respond to model outputs are shaped by power relations between states, corporations, and communities. Environmental social work brings an explicitly justice-oriented lens to these developments. It insists that AI-assisted climate action must be accountable to frontline communities, indigenous knowledge systems, and intergenerational equity rather than solely to technocratic metrics of risk reduction or economic efficiency.

Chapter 18 on the evolving workplace traces the implications of AI for labor markets, working conditions, and the dignity of work. Building on histories of industrial and digital transformation, it examines how algorithmic management, platform-mediated labor, and automation alter employment opportunities, job quality, and workers' bargaining power. AI is used to sort applicants, schedule shifts, monitor performance, and optimize workflows. These practices can reinforce precarious employment, intensify surveillance, and widen the gap between high- and low-skilled workers. At the same time, AI can support new forms of training, career navigation, and workplace accommodations, which may benefit workers who face barriers due to disability, migration status, or caregiving responsibilities. The chapter positions social workers as essential actors in advocating for technological fairness. This advocacy includes supporting workers affected by displacement, participating in policy debates about regulation and social protection, and collaborating with unions and community organizations to contest harmful uses of algorithmic control.

International social work and global issues provide a final vantage point in Part III, highlighting applications in humanitarian assistance, conflict and displacement, global health, and transnational governance. Tools such as crisis mapping, early warning systems, translation and communication technologies, and analytic platforms for targeting aid can enhance coordination and responsiveness in complex emergencies. Chapter 19 also shows how these technologies embed the priorities, biases, and security logics of powerful states, donors, and corporations. Data extracted from crisis-affected populations may be repurposed for surveillance or commercial use, while AI-driven classifications influence who is recognized as a legitimate refugee, a security threat, or a deserving recipient of assistance. A decolonial and culturally responsive lens is proposed to counter the uncritical export of AI systems designed in high-income contexts, emphasizing local ownership, self-determination, and solidarity as guiding principles.

Taken together, the chapters in Part III recast AI as part of the structural fabric within which social problems are produced, perceived, and contested. Advocacy, environmental governance, labor markets, and international aid emerge as sites where algorithmic tools can either entrench existing hierarchies or open new spaces for accountability and redistribution of voice. In contrast to the service-oriented applications highlighted in Part II, Part III underscores that social work engagement with AI must extend to these macro-level dynamics, where decisions about data,

models, and infrastructures shape the very conditions under which justice claims can be articulated and heard.

2.4 Part IV—AI in Social Work Education and Research (Chaps. 20–21)

Part IV turns to the spaces where social work knowledge and professional identities are produced, examining how AI is reshaping education and research as mutually reinforcing enterprises. Across these chapters, AI is not treated as a peripheral technical topic. It is presented as part of the conditions under which learning, inquiry, and professional judgment now take place. The analysis foregrounds how AI-mediated tools alter pedagogical relationships, research practices, and how evidence and expertise are defined within the profession.

In social work education, AI is situated within a broader transformation of higher learning. Simulation environments, virtual clients, adaptive learning platforms, and generative tools are used to create more varied opportunities for practice, feedback, and reflection. These technologies can diversify exposure to client scenarios, support skills rehearsal in lower-risk settings, and personalize learning pathways for students with different needs and backgrounds. At the same time, they reconfigure assessment, supervision, and academic integrity. This raises questions about what counts as an authentic demonstration of competence and how to evaluate learning in AI-mediated environments. Chapter 20, therefore, emphasizes the need for critical digital pedagogy that teaches students to interpret and interrogate algorithmic systems rather than accepting them as neutral utilities. Faculty development is central, since instructors must learn to integrate AI into curricula in ways that align with social work values, attend to equity and accessibility, and respect the emotional and relational dimensions of learning. Discussions of inclusive design, trauma-informed use of simulations, and participatory curriculum development underscore that the integration of AI into education should itself be guided by principles of co-creation and shared governance.

In social work research, AI is presented as a methodological catalyst that cuts across descriptive, predictive, experimental, and conceptual work. Techniques such as machine learning, natural language processing, and network analysis extend what can be done with administrative records, practice notes, policy documents, social media, and other complex data sources. Researchers employ AI to uncover patterns in service trajectories, model risk and resilience, evaluate interventions, and synthesize large bodies of qualitative and mixed-methods evidence. Chapter 21 is explicit that methodological innovation does not replace the need for careful theorizing, robust research design, and attention to context. Choices about model specification, outcome variables, training data, and evaluation metrics are both technical and conceptual. They determine which realities are rendered visible, which are flattened or obscured, and whose experiences are treated as central. Transparency,

reproducibility, and participation are proposed as key criteria for responsible AI-informed research, alongside attention to how data practices intersect with structural inequalities.

Taken together, the chapters in Part IV treat AI in education and research as profoundly interconnected. The tools used to study social problems and interventions help define what counts as legitimate knowledge, and these epistemic hierarchies in turn shape the competencies that education seeks to cultivate. AI thus becomes a lens through which to reconsider longstanding questions about the purposes of social work education and research. These include whose knowledges are centered, how power circulates through evidence-making, and how professional training can prepare practitioners to navigate and critically reshape an increasingly data-saturated world.

2.5 Part V—*Ethical Considerations and Future Directions* **(Chaps. 22–23)**

Part V returns the book to explicitly normative and forward-looking terrain by focusing on ethical challenges, governance, and the cultivation of AI literacy and competency within the profession. The chapters treat ethics not as a late-stage add-on to technological innovation but as a structuring concern that must shape how AI is imagined, designed, implemented, and evaluated in social work. Together, they ask what kinds of institutional arrangements, professional capacities, and community engagements are required if AI is to support rather than undermine commitments to equity, justice, and human dignity.

Chapter 22 moves beyond general statements of principle to examine how ethical commitments can be translated into concrete institutional and regulatory arrangements. It outlines typologies of risk and proposes ways of distinguishing low-risk from high-risk AI applications in social work, with particular attention to systems that affect liberty, entitlements, and exposure to state intervention. Questions of transparency, contestability, and due process are addressed in relation to procurement, implementation, and oversight practices. The analysis foregrounds the roles of agencies, professional associations, regulators, and technology vendors in establishing clear lines of accountability, creating mechanisms for impact assessment and auditing. It also highlights the need to ensure that affected individuals and communities have avenues for redress. Governance is not treated as a purely top-down affair. The chapter emphasizes participatory and community-based approaches to setting norms for acceptable AI use, including advisory bodies, co-governance structures, and partnerships with civil society organizations. It alerts readers to the risks of ethics washing, in which aspirational guidelines are adopted without substantial changes to data practices or decision-making structures. The chapter argues that effective governance must be resourced, enforceable, and responsive to evolving technological and social conditions.

Chapter 23 turns to the capacities that social workers, educators, researchers, and organizations need to participate meaningfully in this governance landscape and in the design and critique of AI systems. AI literacy is conceptualized as more than basic technical familiarity. It encompasses critical data literacy, understanding of how models are trained and evaluated, awareness of common failure modes and biases, and the ability to interpret and communicate the limitations of algorithmic outputs in specific practice contexts. Competency frameworks are outlined at multiple levels, including individual practitioners and students, supervisory and managerial roles, and organizational and community stakeholders. These discussions stress that AI literacy is inseparable from ethical and political literacy. Being competent with AI involves recognizing how systems interact with structural racism, ableism, class inequality, and other forms of oppression. It also involves knowing when and how to challenge the use of particular tools and being able to advocate for alternatives or safeguards. The chapter proposes strategies for embedding AI-related competencies into pre-service education, continuing professional development, and leadership training. It also highlights the importance of aligning these efforts with broader initiatives in digital inclusion and community technology education.

Taken together, the chapters in Part V position ethical deliberation, governance, and capacity building as central to the future of AI in social work rather than as afterthoughts. They suggest that the trajectories outlined in earlier parts will be shaped not only by technological advances, but also by the extent to which social workers and the communities they serve can develop the knowledge, skills, and institutional leverage needed to steer AI toward purposes that are compatible with the profession's core values. In this framing, future directions for AI in social work are inseparable from the creation of governance structures and literacy initiatives that enable practitioners and communities to act as informed, critical, and collectively empowered participants in technological change.

3 Cross-Cutting Challenges and Future Directions for AI in Social Work

Across this book, AI appears in diverse guises and settings, yet a common set of tensions recurs. These tensions are not simply technical problems to be solved. They are reflections of deeper questions about what kind of social work is enacted when algorithmic systems become part of its infrastructure.

3.1 Human Relationships, Care, and Algorithmic Systems

Many of the chapters in Parts II and IV show AI entering spaces that have historically been organized around face-to-face interaction and relational judgment. These include child welfare investigations, mental health encounters, school consultations,